The Cake

By Bekah Brunstetter

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

ACTRESS 1: *Macy and Della (In the original script Macy is African-American)*
ACTRESS 2: *Jen*

(Scene opens with Macy and Jen walking down the main street of Jen's hometown in North Carolina – It is quaint and filled with Southern charm. NOTE: Both Jen and Della should have varying degrees of a southern drawl, while Macy is definitely from NYC but may or may not have an NY accent)

MACY: **(Pg 33)** I drove down through here, in high school, it was my first time going anywhere south of Philly. When my mom dropped me off at the bus that morning, she was like, "Careful down there. It's different down there." The more south we got, the billboards started to change. They were all lit up like beach t-shirts. "Evolution is a fairy tale for grown-ups." "'Don't make me come down there.' – God." Or just "JESUS!"

JEN: That's one's my favorite.

MACY: They were all paid for by churches. That's when I realized that [in North Carolina], church is just another chain store.

JEN: Well, that's a generalization. *(Diverting)* At least down here, you can have a real house. With countertops. And CLOSETS. A whole closet just for winter coats. If we lived here, we could have a staircase and a big yard with a dogwood tree and a tire swing and a little creek out back –

MACY: Here? For actual life? Nope.

JEN: *(Looks around her old hometown) (Beat)* **(Pg 57-58)** It was a good part of my life. For so long . . . Every time someone says that God doesn't exist, a little something

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inside of me burns – it goes DING. But with fire. I'm of two different minds. [New York and North Carolina] All the time.

MACY: **(Pg 59)** Does it ding when you kiss me? *(Jen can't respond)* Does it?

JEN: . . . Not every time, but - *(A horrible confession. Macy and Jen stare at each other in silence)*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *In today's political climate, it is easy to demonize those who think differently . . .*
ACTRESS 2: *. . . Particularly when we believe their beliefs infringe on others' rights.*
ACTRESS 1: *The right to refuse service to members of the LGBTQ community has become explosive.*
ACTRESS 2: *A legal matter? Perhaps . . . But it's the individual emotional turmoil surrounding this issue that may never be resolved.*
ACTRESS 1: *This selection whittles the right to refuse service for religious reasons down to the most personal of human connections.*
ACTRESS 2: *And in doing so, it welcomes you to see Della, the baker in our story, as a real person.*
ACTRESS 1: *You may agree or disagree with her struggle to find the best path, but the need for relationships as we navigate this crazy world is universal.*
TOGETHER: *The Cake by Bekah Brunstetter*

(The women reach their destination – Della's Cake shop)

JEN: **(Pg 19-21)** The Cake! Cake, cake, cake. *(Her excitement is palpable)*

MACY: *(A sad huzzah)* Cake. Does it really matter?

JEN: I just want it to be perfect!

MACY: Can we pleeeeeease just go to the Food Tiger where it's thirty bucks and nobody asks questions?

JEN: It's a Food ***Lion***. [And, no] I want to get it from here.

MACY: Ma'am, can I get your eyes for a second, like your full eyes? *(Jen looks at her fully)* There's already enough drama doing this here. I'm just asking, why do we have to?

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JEN: She was my mom's best friend. There are just things that I . . . my mom would've . . . I just want to do it like we talked about doing it. Even though she's not . . . *(She has tears in her eyes)*

MACY: *(Comforting)* Okay . . . Hey. We'll get it from here. *(They enter the store as Della emerges from the back – Actress shifts roles from Macy to Della)*

DELLA: Is that . . ? No! Jenny Penny?! OH MY GOODNESS! It's you! *(so excited to see her)*

JEN: It's me! *(They hug as long-lost friends, then Della notices Macy)*

DELLA: How's your daddy?

JEN: He's good! He got a boat! He named it Debra after Mom . . . **(Pg 22-25)** OH! When do you go on the show? *(to Macy)* Della's about to be a contestant on The Big American Bake-Off!

DELLA: Six weeks I'm going! But get this, once I get there I am sworn to SECRECY. I can't tell anyone if I won or not 'til they air it!

JEN: Well, I'm gonna watch you every week and cheer you on.

DELLA: Thanks, sweetheart, we'll see, we'll see. I'm trying not to think about it! So, what're you up to this visit? *(Jen waves her engagement ring so Della can see)* You're getting ***married***?! AHHHHHHHHH! *(Screams in excitement)*

JEN: I know!

DELLA: I didn't even know you were seeing anybody, why didn't you tell me! Lemme see that diamond, girl, gimme that bling. It's a beautiful ring. So you're doin' it down here?

JEN: Yup!

DELLA: Your mama is dying all over again right now!! She is watching and she is so stinkin' mad she is not here. I am gonna make your cake! Now what're your colors?

JEN: Emerald and midnight blue.

DELLA: Well, I wanna hear all about him! *(Jen panics, looks to Macy)* . . .

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JEN: **(Pg 21)** This is my – this is Macy. She's with me.

DELLA: **(Pg 23-24)** . . . Beg pardon? *(Della realizes what Jen is saying)* . . . Oh!

JEN: Macy's my . . . I'm sorry to spring it on you, but – yeah! So . . .

DELLA: *(Trying)* Well, congratulations to you two. When, ah. When is the wedding?

JEN: I didn't want a super long engagement, so we're just kind of throwing it together. [Six months]. *(She senses Della's discomfort. It kills her)*

DELLA: Well . . . October, is it?

JEN: I know it's late notice . . . I – I shoulda called. *(To Macy)* She gets a lot of orders. *(To Della)* If you don't – I'm sure you're super busy –

DELLA: You know what, I am so sorry, but you're right. I think I am all backed up, around that time.

JEN: It's okay – I understand . . It's fine, it's so fine, we can get it somewhere else . .

DELLA: It's not – because – it's just I have a lot - I am so sorry –

JEN: (*Humiliated)* No, I'm sorry, it's totally fine, its . . .

DELLA: Stop by again and see me, whenever you . . .

JEN: . . . Definitely *(Macy and Jen leave the shop)*

******* Later that night ********

MACY: **(Pg 35-36)** She's wrong. The Cake Lady.

JEN: Della . . she has every right to say no if she's not comfortable.

MACY: She is wrong.

JEN: She doesn't think she is.

MACY: Look at me. . . **SHE IS WRONG**.

JEN: *(Jen is quiet, puts her head in her hands, a long pause)* I shouldn't've gone there. You shouldn't've seen that.

MACY: *(Softly)* What'd you think was going to happen?

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JEN: I had this whole speech prepared. I had lines. I was going to say them to her. I kept imagining myself saying it, all calm and confident. But then I saw her face. And I just. I couldn't. I feel like such a tiny piece of shit.

MACY: You're not shit. You're hopeful.

JEN: Hope is stupid. *(defeated)*

MACY: . . . You could change her.

JEN: Della? No, thank you.

MACY: But if you don't push her to change then they never will . . .

JEN: They?

MACY: All of them.

JEN: I'm not talking about all of them. I am talking about one person, who I love, who I know.

MACY: I'm just asking – do we really have to do this here?

JEN: YES. My mom wanted me to get married here. Yes. We have to.

MACY: We do not "have" to do anything, okay? We are shoving ourselves through some narrow system that was not even designed to support us!

JEN: All I ask is that you just try and be respectful of the people down here.

MACY: . . . I don't respect these people.

JEN: . . . But I'm one of them.

MACY: No . . . you're not

JEN: *(Softly)* I kinda am.

******** The next day*********

(Jen returns to Della's Cake Shop by herself)

JEN: **(Pg 39-41)** You still open?

DELLA: Where's your . . . . ?

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JEN: She's at Starbucks. She thinks I'm looking at [wedding] favors. Which is of course my next stop. *(long awkward silence)* I'm sorry I haven't been down. As much.

DELLA: Oh, sweetie, that's alright. You got your life up there . . A whole other life. *(Beat. She tries)* How, ah. Is your daddy excited about the wedding?

JEN: He's trying to be. *(awkward silence)* **(Pg 42)** I totally get it. I don't want you to think that I don't get it. Why you can't – why you're too busy.

DELLA: I am so sorry, I looked again, and October is just going to be impossible

JEN: Della. It's okay. **(Pg 44)** I know you don't think it's right.

DELLA: What do ***you*** think?

JEN: . . . That I love her. But I can't stop wondering how my mom would feel.

DELLA: Sweetie . . .

JEN: I keep ignoring it, but it's a question. *(Beat)* What do you think she would've said? . . . Just tell me. Please. What she would think. *(Beat)*

DELLA: **(Pg 46)** It's – It's not what God intended . . . **(Pg 44)** I think it would break her heart. *(This stabs at Jen. It kills her)*

JEN: . . . Yeah *(Tears come. She fights them, but can't keep them back)*

****** Cut away to Macy, speaking to the audience ********

MACY: **(Pg 45)** She's really a good person. She's warm and she's giving and she won't ever think of herself first. Sometimes I just want to shake her, ***think of yourself, it comes so naturally to everyone else***, but she won't eat until everyone is fed. When I get a cold she makes me garlic tea even though she hates garlic, it makes her gag. When her mom was sick she dropped everything and moved back down here. . . . She has nightmares she's falling into flames . . . Because of people like . . **(Pg 48)** Jesus, I am so tired of tolerating this. I am so tired of being nice. Why do you hate me?! *(She starts to tear up)* Why . . . why . . . why.

******** Back to Jen and Della in Della's Cake Shop **********

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JEN: **(Pg 61-62)** *(Composing herself)* I used to have nightmares. I said ***goddamn*** in front of my mom and it made her skin melt off her face. That's how scared I was. Of a WORD. She's been gone almost five years and I'm still terrified of disappointing her. That's on me

DELLA: *(Gently)* **(Pg 47-48)** It's just the way I see it – and I'm just trying to explain – if God intended everybody to love on everybody, there would be means . . . The Bible made it very clear. *(Firmly)* It's God's **WORD**. He says so, in Romans 1:26. *

JEN: **(Pg 62-63)** *(completely distraught)* Macy's the only person I ever loved. I tried not to love her, but I do. She is beautiful and she's wonderful and she's strong. We're a family. And I pushed her away because I am so ripped in two. I am straddling two worlds. . . I'm so SICK of being scared.

DELLA: *(Heart breaking)* Jenny . . . . I would love more than anything, truly anything in this world, to make your cake. But . . .

JEN: I don't need you to make me a cake. I need you to ***love*** me.

DELLA: I do love you. I have really been searching through my heart. But I just. I ***can't*** support. What you're doing. I am so sorry to say that.

JEN: I tried not to love her. But I do. I love her so much, I love her . . .

DELLA: I know, sweetie. But still. It just - does not sit right with me. *(Beat)*

JEN: Well, then I don't know if I can have you in my life anymore.

DELLA: Oh, no, sweetie – please –

JEN: No, I think that's how it's gotta be right now.

DELLA: *(closes her eyes. Lets it sting)* I am very sorry to hear that.

JEN: Me too. *(Neither is sure what to do.)* . . . Bye, Della. *(Jen leaves. And Della stands alone, the breath knocked out of her)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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**** Romans 1:26 New International Version (NIV)***
Because of this, God gave them over to shameful lusts. Even their women exchanged natural sexual relations for unnatural ones.

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